although the leadership still viewed Kashmir as the most important front and it remained the one on which Lashkar focused above all else, that jihad was a shadow of what it once had been. There was internal debate about how deeply involved it should become in the Afghan insurgency and to what degree Lashkar should cooperate with other outfits, particularly those attacking the Pakistani state. Yet, in reality, there was only so much the group could do to halt its members from moving in that direction if they chose to do so. The jihadi milieu in which Lashkar operated by this time was protean, characterized by a mélange of networks that existed alongside, and were interwoven with, institutional outfits. The intensifying integration of established groups and the rise of new ones brought a concomitant atomization, since the burgeoning array of opportunities for collaboration meant actors could shop around for like-minded allies. Militancy in Pakistan had become a buyer's market.

As collaboration increased between Lashkar members and the Taliban, TTP, the Haqqani Network and other Deobandi militants, the sectarian divide shrank, though it did not disappear. Lashkar leaders still viewed Deobandis with a fair degree of disdain, but this mattered less than before. The old loci of activity continued to hold some utility, but new ones had emerged and all of these now overlapped to a greater extent than hitherto. First, Afghanistan had become a focal point for every major militant outfit as well as a host of smaller networks and splinter groups. Second, India continued to receive significant attention from Lashkar. In a sign of the atomization and integration that was taking place, Abdur Rehman Syed, who had been distancing himself from Lashkar for several years, finally quit the group in 2008. He launched his own outfit called Jund-ul-Fida [Army of Fidayeen], which incorporated the Lashkar unit he had overseen in Karachi for attacks against India. It operated under Ilyas Kashmiri's 313 Brigade and was intended to carry out operations primarily in India, though Syed aspired to attack other non-Islamic countries as well.[124] The Haqqani Network also contributed to the jihad against India by attacking that country's interests in Afghanistan. Third, sectarian attacks continued in Pakistan. Not only did a number of the insurgents bring with them their viciously sectarian agendas, but exacerbating sectarian tensions also constituted another means of destabilizing the state.

This highlights the introduction of a new locus of activity: revolutionary jihad against the state. Historically militants had been motivated either by